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The Father's Embrace

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The Father's Embrace

Day 12

But when he [the prodigal son] was still a great way off, his father saw him and had compassion, and ran and fell on his neck and kissed him. And the son said to him, "Father, I have sinned against heaven and in your sight, and am no longer worthy to be called your son." But the father said to his servants, "Bring out the best robe and put it on him, and put a ring on his hand and sandals on his feet. And bring the fatted calf here and kill it, and let us eat and be merry; for this my son was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found." (Luke 15:20-24)

Stories have a way of sneaking past our defenses. We hear the story, something within us resonates with it, and then we realize it is speaking to us. Jesus told this story to open our eyes to the truth of how our Father feels about us.

A father had two sons. The older son worked hard on his father's farm and followed the rules. The younger son did not. He wanted to do his own thing. So he asked his father for his inheritance, went to a far-away place and squandered all that his father had given him. Until ... he ended up feeding pigs and eating their food to stay alive.

Then the prodigal son came to his senses and realized that even his father's servants were better off than he. So he decided to go home. Along the way, he thought of what he might say to appease his father. He would admit his sin. He would forfeit his sonship. He would ask only to be a servant in his father's house.

As the son neared home, the father saw him coming! He ran to meet his son, flung his arms around him and kissed him. Can you see the father running on his tottery, old legs? Can you see the joyful tears streaming down his cheeks?

The father didn't think about what his son had done; that the money was squandered, that his heart had been torn with grief, that the prodigal had sinned. The father didn't bargain with his son: "You are welcomed home if...." He was simply

overjoyed at his return. And so he had the servants bring fine clothes to replace his son's tattered rags. This was cause for celebration. "*My son* was dead and is alive again."

"*My son.*" Can you hear the father's adoration? "My precious son is alive!"

Relationship with a lost family is restored!

The older, responsible son was working in his father's fields. But when he arrived home and heard that a party was being given for his younger brother, he was mad. The thought of welcoming home this sinner, this failure, this lazy good-for-nothing made him angry. For all these years, he had done right. It was he who deserved a party.

The father reassured his older son of his position in the family and invited him to join the celebration. Again his words are laced with love. "Son, you are always with me, and all that I have is yours. It was right that we should make merry and be glad, for your brother was dead and is alive again, and was lost and is found."

But the older son viewed his father's actions toward his brother with disdain. His father's heartwarming welcome of this prodigal wasn't fair. His sinful, lazy brother had done nothing to earn such treatment. He was wiser than such nonsense. He was better than that—above forgiveness, above mercy, above his father's grace, above the joy of reunion.

The question is not: Does the father love his sons? Clearly, he loves both.

The critical question is: Will the sons accept their father's undeserved, unconditional love?

You and I, along with every human being on the planet, are cherished by God. But we each have a choice as to how we respond. That choice doesn't affect the Father's love for us, but it does have a monumental impact on our lives.

Ponder for a Moment

Where are you in this story? Which son are you? In what ways might you be a combination of the two?

Think of a time when someone was overjoyed to see you. What did their joy tell you about how they felt about you?